

Case Study: Phishing Email Scam (Inspired by the 2020 Twitter Bitcoin Hack)

- **What the crime is:**

Phishing is a type of cybercrime where attackers trick individuals into revealing sensitive information such as passwords, bank details, or login credentials. In the 2020 Twitter hack, attackers used social engineering to gain access to internal systems. This allowed them to take over high-profile accounts and promote a cryptocurrency scam. It is considered a form of fraud and identity theft.

- **How it typically happens (step-by-step):**

The attacker sends a convincing email or message pretending to be from a trusted source like a bank or company. The victim clicks a malicious link and enters their login credentials on a fake website. In advanced cases, attackers may contact employees directly and manipulate them into sharing access. Once access is gained, the attacker exploits accounts or systems for financial gain.

- **Who is usually targeted:**

Common targets include employees of large organizations, social media users, and individuals with limited cybersecurity awareness. High-profile individuals or companies are often targeted because of their influence and access to large audiences. However, everyday users are also vulnerable, especially those who frequently use online banking or email services.

- **Consequences of the crime:**

Victims may suffer financial loss, identity theft, and privacy breaches. Organizations can face reputational damage and legal consequences. In the Twitter case, millions of followers were exposed to a scam, leading to widespread distrust. Long-term impacts include stricter security policies and increased awareness of cyber threats.

Source: Public reports on the 2020 Twitter Bitcoin scam (widely covered by major news outlets like BBC and The New York Times).